

Black or white?

The terms White Hat and Black Hat originate from old western films where the villains usually wore black hats and heroes wore lighter, or white hats

Hacker lingo

The titles of this article are written in hacker speak aka 1337 \$p33k< (elite speak) where numbers and symbols which look are used to represent alphabets

Kshitij Sobti

kshitij.sobti@9dot9.in

1|\7r0DU(710|\|

Man is a curious animal. Few people can get by a day without wondering about the working of the many things that surround them. How a bird stays in air by flapping it's wings, or how people get work done despite posting on Twitter every 5 minutes. Our curiosity drives us to understand the inner working of things despite the potential harm. People have taken great risks to examine the workings of this universe, and we are wiser for it.

With computers our curiosity found another dimension to explore. How does the software work? How did someone manage to make an algorithm that works so fast? We want to know. For the most part the information is all there,

a software itself is merely data about how it will operate.

When you look at it in the clearest sense, everything on your computer is merely data that you already have access to. It is a collection of binary instructions which direct the functioning of your computer, there is nothing stopping you from finding out exactly how, if you are capable of understanding it at its lowest level. Network communication is merely the transmission of collections of bits from one computer to another in such a way that the devices can influence each others functioning. There are no physical limitations on what we can do with the data, the boundaries here are legal.

It is like owning a toy car, but being forbidden to open it up and see how everything works together. A situation many a curious child will sympathize with. The legal framework is designed to protect the rights of the author

of the code. However in doing that it also curbs the freedom of people who are merely curious, with no harm intended. We can debate till the end of time about whether it is better for people to have freedom or whether such restrictions only manage to push an otherwise healthy curiosity to a crime. As you might remember though, curiosity killed the cat. The dogs are safe, so I guess its OK.

7|-|3 V\|I-|173 I-|475

Some people however just don't grow up, while once they were breaking toy cars, they now break code. For these such people hacking is merely a digital offshoot of their curiosity. The limitation they face seem so artificial, everything they need to hack into the code is right there, like the screws hidden behind stickers in toys.

To say they are misunderstood and misrepresented would be a gross understatement. Hackers

are perhaps most associated with teenage geeks who live within six inches of their computer keyboards. Eccentrics with non existing social lives, as it is for anyone whose work involves something that will merely annoy people.

The good news and the bad is that hacking is no longer a purely illegal domain, and as such is no longer as "cool" as it used to be. Today we have ethical hackers, whose curiosity and determination is respected instead of being restricted. It seems many companies have realized that such traits are rather good to have in their employees. Known as White Hat Hackers, these people tread on the same familiar hacking territory but in the sandbox of their organization.

37|-|1(4L I-|4(|<1|\|9

Many people regard Ethical Hacking is an oxymoron, a phrase invented by offended

Donning the White Cap

